Weizheng Lai

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Research Fields

Development Economics, Political Economy, Labor Economics, Applied Microeconometrics

Positions

Academic Appointments

2026– Assistant Professor in Economics, *Trinity College Dublin*
2025–2026 Visiting Assistant Professor of Economics, *Bowdoin College*

Academic Affiliations

2026– Research Associate, *Centre for Economics, Policy, and History (CEPH)*

Short-Term Research Positions

Jan 2027 Visiting Researcher, *Institute for Emerging Economies, Bank of Finland*
Summer 2022 Short-Term Consultant, *Development Research Group, World Bank*

Education

2025 Ph.D. Economics, *University of Maryland*
2021 M.A. Economics, *University of Maryland*
2019 B.A. Economics and B.S. Mathematics, *Wuhan University*

Research

Publications

1. "Property Rights, Fiscal Capacity, and Social Capacity: The Lasting Impact of the Taiping Rebellion," with Lixin Colin Xu and Li Yang, forthcoming at *Journal of Economic Growth*.
2. "Anti-Corruption and Political Trust: Evidence from China," with Ming Fang and Congling Xia, *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*, Vol. 234, June 2025.
3. "China's Anticorruption Campaign and Civil Servant Fever," with Xun Li, *Journal of Law and Economics*, Vol. 67, No. 2, May 2024.
4. "The Effect of Education on Voter Turnout in China's Rural Elections," *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*, Vol. 221, May 2024.
5. "Housing Market Regulations and Strategic Divorce Propensity in China," with James Alm and Xun Li, *Journal of Population Economics*, Vol. 35, July 2022.
6. "Role of Professionalism in the Policy Response to COVID-19: Does a Public Health or Medical Background Help?," with Xun Li, Qianqian Wan, and Xi Chen, *China Economic Review*, Vol. 71, February 2022.

Working Papers

7. "Migrant Integration and Social Stability," with Yu Qiu.
8. "The Intergenerational Effects of Early-Adulthood Adversity"
9. "Geopolitical Tensions, Economic Opportunities, and Political Responses: Evidence from Japan," with Yu Qiu.

Select Work in Progress

10. "The Impact of Trade on Foreign Policy Preferences: The Case of Taiwan"
11. "Feudalism and Democracy: Evidence from Weimar Germany," with Kartikeya Batra, Arseniy Braslavskiy, and Ethan Kaplan.

Professional Activities

Referee

Agribusiness: An International Journal • *British Medical Journal: Leader* • *China: An International Journal* • *Economic Journal* • *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization* • *Journal of Economic Growth* • *Journal of Human Resources* • *Journal of Population Economics* • *Oxford Development Studies* • *Public Choice* • *Review of Economics of the Household*

Presentations

2027 Bank of Finland (planned)
2026 Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (Division of Social Science), University of New Mexico, Trinity College Dublin, University of Bremen, Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting
2025 West Virginia University, University of Adelaide, University of Bath, Peking University (National School of Development)
2024 Chinese Economists Society North America Meeting, Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting, Urban Economics Association North America Meeting, DC Political Economy Center Workshop, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting, University of Queensland
2022 University of Queensland
2021 Global Labor Organization & Renmin University Joint Conference

Grants and Awards

2024 Chiang Ching-kuo Doctoral Fellowship, *Chiang Ching-kuo Foundation* (declined)
2024 Ann G. Wylie Dissertation Fellowship, *University of Maryland* [$20,000]
2024 Jacob K. Goldhaber Travel Grant, *University of Maryland*
2023 Faculty-Student Research Award (with Kartikeya Batra, Arseniy Braslavskiy, and Ethan Kaplan), *University of Maryland* [$10,000]
2023 Prize for Economics Poster Competition, *University of Maryland*
2022 Best Third-Year Paper Prize, *University of Maryland*
2022 Melville Ulmer Prize (Best Second-Year Paper Prize), *University of Maryland*
2019 Distinguished Graduate, *Wuhan University*
2015–2019 Academic Excellence Scholarship (4x), *Wuhan University*

Teaching

Courses Taught

Trinity College Dublin

Macroeconomics for Management (Undergrad), Spring 2026
Intermediate Microeconomics (Undergrad), Fall 2026
Research Methods for Economic Policy Analysis (MSc), Fall 2026

Bowdoin College

Intermediate Microeconomics, Spring 2026
China's Environmental Governance (Independent Study), Spring 2026
Political Economy of Development, Fall 2025
Econometrics, Fall 2025

University of Maryland

Intermediate Microeconomics (Undergrad), Summer 2023
Principles of Microeconomics (Undergrad; Tutor), Spring 2025
Econometrics Sequence (PhD; TA), 2022–2024
Probability and Statistics (PhD; TA), Summer 2022–2024

Undergraduate Advising

2026–2027 Bachelor's Dissertation Supervisor, *Trinity College Dublin*: Hilary Brett, Thomas Graham, Milla Li, Lochlann Nairn, Hezamary Paul, and Isaac Sheehan
2026 Honors Thesis Reader, *Bowdoin College*: Liam Foley

Skills

Programming: Stata, Matlab, R
Languages: English (fluent), Mandarin (native), Japanese (beginner), German (beginner)